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Culture (OWC): [Zulu \(FX20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1951

Coverage Date: 1800-1951

Place Coverage

Makhanya tribe, Umbumbulu township, Umlazi District, KwaZulu-Natal Province, South Africa

Section Title(S): Husband's Brother • Sister

Husband's Brother

A woman calls her husband's brother *mfowethu* because she has been drawn into her husband's descent group and is identified in attitude with him. Similarly she addresses her husband's father's brother's sons as *mfowethu*. Further, as her husband divides his brothers into the eldest, *mfowethu omkhulu*, and the younger ones, *mfowethu omncane*, she does the same. She shows special respect towards the eldest brother, knowing that this man may become her guardian if her husband dies. Something of the same respect is carried over to all brothers older than her husband. With the younger ones she can behave more freely, though not to the extent of a joking relationship.

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She must cook for any of her husband's brothers visiting him, and must show them hospitality. If a brother becomes a widower and her husband is fond of him, she may have to work in that brother's kraal, keep it clean and cook there for him.

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The attitude of a wife towards her husband's brothers is coloured by the fact that under the custom of the levirate any one of them at her choice may be

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called upon to *ngena* her after her husband's death. If she specially likes a husband's brother she will therefore be careful to please him during her husband's lifetime.

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Siblings-In-Law

In general the application of the term *mfowethu* implies fraternal status of the same generation, to which attach the duties of mutual help and consultation, rising to the paternal duties of guardianship, discipline and support as maximal seniority within the class is reached. The social value of the latter obligations engenders respect in persons more junior in the class.

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Kin Relationships

Sister (father's daughter)	} <i>dadewethu</i>	Reciprocals: Brother and sister
Father's Brother's daughter		Father's brother's children
Husband's Sister		Brother's wife
Brother's Wife		Husband's brother and sister
Husband's Brother's Wife		Husband's brother's wife.

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Sister

During childhood a sister is as close to a child as his brother is, so that  **151** terminological distinctions such as those for Brother (q.v.) are to be found. The term *intombazana yakwethu*—young girl of our (mother)—is used descriptively of a sister by the same mother as oneself, and *intombazana kababa*—young girl of (our) father—is used of a girl by the same father but any mother.

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